

ATi get driver driven

Nvidia drivers are generally considered to be superior compared to other drivers in the video card market, but lately, ATi broke new ground by introducing new features in the latest Catalyst drivers. The company has features such as resetting the video card, over-clocking, better support for Linux and a better interface. The star of the features is VPU Recover that lets you reset only the video card. This will be very



useful as the entire system becomes unusable after a system crash. A hardware crash occurs if a hardware piece is unable to communicate with the corresponding device driver. When the VPU Recover feature is enabled, the display driver will be able to detect when the video card stops responding to its commands. Once the hardware hangs, the system will be restored depending on the severity of the crash. If both fail, a software rendering method is used to restore the system. The company has also introduced the error report feature, similar to the one in Windows XP. After any video card related crash the system will send an error report to ATi; if desired, this feature can be disabled.

snapshot

Blaster worm
infected more than
5,00,000
machines in
August

Source: Symantec

Half-Life 2 stolen 2

"I need the assistance of the community" was the title of the Gabe Newell post confirming that the source code of *Half Life 2* was stolen. Newell is the founder and managing director of Valve Software, the developer of the game. In a post on the games forum Newell said that



around September 11 2003, someone gained access to his mailbox. The hackers then managed install keystroke loggers on several systems at Valve Software, exploiting a buffer-

overflow error in Microsoft Outlook's preview pane. These tools apparently helped the hackers copy the source code.

Newell appealed to the Half-Life community to help nab the culprits; any information regarding the incident can be mailed to help-valve@valvesoftware.com. Fortunately, the hackers couldn't lay their hands on the maps and sounds that are vital to recreate the game as visualised by the game developers.

Wheeling off

Once hailed as the future of personal transportation, the Segway human transporter is now in trouble—all thanks to a power problem. The Segway is a two-wheeled device on which the rider stands up on a platform between two wheels; the device is powered by a battery that runs an electric motor, and the vehicle is steered by a handlebar. A combination of onboard computers and gyro-

scopes keeps the rider balanced on the two-wheeler.

Segway and US Consumer Product Safety Commission (CPSC), found that if the batteries run down, there may not be enough power to keep the vehicle upright. Segway has recalled all 6,000 machines sold so far, and all current human transporters have received a software upgrade that should fix the problem.



quoteworthy

"The primary mission of Google is to get you what you want, rather than what someone thinks you want"

Eric Schmidt, CEO of Google, while discussing the future of search. Google is looking at personalisation as a means to improve its search results

"The cellphone market is enjoying 100 per cent growth. Each month, one million new users are added"

R. N. Jha, India's Minister of Telecommunications and Information Technology, speaking at the Telecom 2003 trade fair in Geneva

"But if you think you can experience the power of the Internet on a 1-inch screen, you've got to be out of your mind."

Martin Cooper, inventor of the cell phones playing down the 3G hype, stating that 3G will continue to disappoint

tomorrow's technology

Oily e-paper

E-paper has the ability to exchange the information displayed electronically. E-Ink uses positively charged white particles and negatively charged black ones, changing the polarity to bring either to the front. Another technology uses half-black and half-white spheres. These are flipped, depending on what is required. These work ade-

quately for text, but neither can display moving images.

Researchers at Philips, Netherlands, have come up with a technique that could overcome this and greatly increase brightness. The display works on electrowetting—a technique that allows for rapid control of fluids at micrometer scales. Each pixel consists of a white substrate,

with an electrode above it. Above that is a layer of coloured oil and water. The water stays on top due to a water-repelling insulator. The oil contracts when a voltage is applied—allowing the white substrate to reflect light. The state changes in a span of 10 milliseconds, which is more than enough for smooth video.